

Australian Community Services & Social Work Sector Glossary

Key Acronyms & Organizations

Government Bodies

- **ACSC** - Australian Community Services Council
- **AIHW** - Australian Institute of Health and Welfare
- **CALD** - Culturally and Linguistically Diverse
- **DCP** - Department of Community Protection (varies by state)
- **DHHS** - Department of Health and Human Services
- **DSS** - Department of Social Services
- **FACS** - Family and Community Services (NSW)
- **NDIA** - National Disability Insurance Agency
- **NDIS** - National Disability Insurance Scheme
- **NIAA** - National Indigenous Australians Agency

Professional Bodies

- **AASW** - Australian Association of Social Workers
- **ACWA** - Australian Community Workers Association
- **ANZASW** - Australian and New Zealand Association of Social Workers
- **PACFA** - Psychotherapy and Counselling Federation of Australia
- **VCOSS** - Victorian Council of Social Service

Frameworks & Systems

- **AOD** - Alcohol and Other Drugs
- **CAF** - Common Assessment Framework
- **CIMS** - Client Information Management System
- **MARAM** - Multi-Agency Risk Assessment and Management
- **OOHC** - Out of Home Care
- **SRS** - Specialist Reporting System
- **VACCA** - Victorian Aboriginal Child Care Agency

Legislative Frameworks

Child Protection

- **Children and Young Persons (Care and Protection) Act** - NSW child protection legislation
- **Child Protection Act** - Victoria's child protection framework
- **Mandatory Reporting** - Legal obligation to report child abuse suspicions
- **Working with Children Check** - Screening for child-related employment

Mental Health

- **Mental Health Act** - State-based mental health legislation
- **Involuntary Treatment** - Compulsory mental health treatment
- **Community Treatment Orders** - Mandated outpatient treatment
- **Mental Health Tribunal** - Independent review body

Disability

- **Disability Discrimination Act 1992** - Federal anti-discrimination law
- **NDIS Act 2013** - National Disability Insurance Scheme legislation
- **Reasonable Adjustments** - Workplace/service modifications for disability
- **Supported Decision Making** - Alternative to guardianship

Privacy & Information

- **Privacy Act 1988** - Federal privacy legislation
- **Health Records Act** - State-based health information protection
- **Information Sharing** - Authorized disclosure between agencies
- **Notifiable Data Breaches** - Mandatory breach reporting

Theoretical Frameworks & Practice Models

Core Practice Approaches

- **Trauma-Informed Practice** - Recognizing trauma's impact on behavior and service delivery
- **Strengths-Based Practice** - Focusing on client assets and capabilities rather than deficits
- **Harm Reduction** - Reducing negative consequences without requiring abstinence
- **Recovery-Oriented Practice** - Supporting personal recovery journey in mental health
- **Person-Centered Practice** - Placing individual at center of service planning
- **Empowerment Practice** - Building client capacity for self-determination

Therapeutic Models

- **Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT)** - Addressing thought patterns and behaviors
- **Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT)** - Skills for emotional regulation and distress tolerance
- **Narrative Therapy** - Re-authoring life stories and externalizing problems
- **Solution-Focused Brief Therapy** - Goal-oriented, present-focused approach

- **Motivational Interviewing** - Collaborative conversation to strengthen motivation for change
- **Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT)** - Mindfulness and values-based intervention

Family & Systems Approaches

- **Family Systems Theory** - Understanding family as interconnected system
- **Structural Family Therapy** - Addressing family hierarchies and boundaries
- **Attachment Theory** - Understanding early relationship patterns
- **Ecological Systems Theory** - Microsystem, mesosystem, exosystem influences
- **Intersectionality** - Multiple, overlapping identity factors

Cultural Frameworks

- **Anti-Oppressive Practice** - Challenging discrimination and power imbalances
- **Cultural Humility** - Ongoing self-reflection and client-centered cultural learning
- **Culturally Responsive Practice** - Adapting services to cultural contexts
- **Indigenous Ways of Knowing** - Traditional knowledge systems and practices
- **Decolonizing Practice** - Challenging Western-dominated service models

Specialized Concepts & Terminology

Mental Health

- **Dual Diagnosis** - Co-occurring mental health and substance use disorders
- **Psychosocial Rehabilitation** - Functional recovery support
- **Psychiatric Disability** - Functional impairment from mental health conditions
- **Lived Experience** - Personal experience of mental health challenges
- **Peer Support** - Mutual support from people with similar experiences
- **Clinical Recovery** - Symptom reduction and functional improvement
- **Personal Recovery** - Individual journey of meaning and purpose

Child & Family Services

- **Family Preservation** - Keeping families together safely
- **Permanency Planning** - Stable, long-term care arrangements
- **Kinship Care** - Placement with family members

- **Therapeutic Foster Care** - Specialized care for traumatized children
- **Reunification** - Returning children to birth family
- **Concurrent Planning** - Dual permanency planning approach

Disability Services

- **Capacity Building** - Developing skills and independence
- **Reasonable and Necessary** - NDIS funding criteria
- **Assistive Technology** - Equipment supporting daily living
- **Supported Independent Living (SIL)** - NDIS accommodation support
- **Individual Funding** - Person-directed funding models
- **Mainstream Services** - Universal services for all citizens

Homelessness & Housing

- **Housing First** - Immediate housing without preconditions
- **Rapid Rehousing** - Quick transition to permanent housing
- **Supportive Housing** - Housing with integrated services
- **Rough Sleeping** - Sleeping in public spaces
- **Couch Surfing** - Temporary accommodation with friends/family
- **Primary Homelessness** - No conventional accommodation

Aboriginal & Torres Strait Islander Services

- **Self-Determination** - Community control over services and decisions
- **Cultural Protocols** - Traditional practices and procedures
- **Connection to Country** - Relationship with traditional lands
- **Stolen Generations** - Children forcibly removed from families
- **Native Title** - Traditional land ownership rights
- **Cultural Safety** - Environment free from cultural harm

Service Delivery Models

Case Management

- **Brokerage Model** - Purchasing services from external providers
- **Clinical Case Management** - Therapy integrated with coordination
- **Assertive Community Treatment** - Intensive, multidisciplinary support
- **Intensive Case Management** - High-frequency, comprehensive support
- **Strengths Case Management** - Asset-based coordination approach

Group Work

- **Psychoeducational Groups** - Information and skill-building focus
- **Process Groups** - Interpersonal dynamics and insight

- **Support Groups** - Peer support and shared experiences
- **Skills Groups** - Specific competency development
- **Therapeutic Communities** - Residential treatment environments

Community Development

- **Asset-Based Community Development** - Building on community strengths
- **Participatory Action Research** - Community-led research and action
- **Community Organizing** - Collective action for social change
- **Capacity Building** - Strengthening community resources and skills
- **Social Capital** - Networks and relationships for mutual benefit

Quality & Standards

Accreditation Bodies

- **Australian Council on Healthcare Standards** - Healthcare quality assurance
- **Quality Innovation Performance (QIP)** - Disability service standards
- **Human Services Quality Framework** - Victorian quality standards
- **National Standards for Mental Health Services** - Mental health quality framework

Practice Standards

- **Code of Ethics** - Professional behavior guidelines
- **Professional Boundaries** - Appropriate relationship limits
- **Supervision Standards** - Regular professional oversight requirements
- **Continuing Professional Development** - Ongoing learning requirements
- **Competency Standards** - Required skills and knowledge

Risk Management

- **Risk Assessment** - Systematic evaluation of potential harm
- **Duty of Care** - Legal obligation to prevent harm
- **Incident Reporting** - Documenting adverse events
- **Critical Incident** - Serious occurrence requiring immediate response
- **Safeguarding** - Protecting vulnerable people from harm

Funding & Commissioning

Funding Models

- **Block Funding** - Fixed amount for service delivery
- **Fee-for-Service** - Payment per service unit
- **Outcomes-Based Funding** - Payment linked to results

- **Individual Funding** - Client-directed funding (e.g., NDIS)
- **Pooled Funding** - Multiple agencies contributing to shared fund

Commissioning Terms

- **Service Level Agreement (SLA)** - Contract specifying service requirements
- **Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)** - Measurable performance targets
- **Output Measures** - Quantifiable service delivery data
- **Outcome Measures** - Changes in client circumstances
- **Performance Monitoring** - Regular assessment of service delivery

Evaluation Concepts

- **Logic Model** - Visual representation of program theory
- **Theory of Change** - Pathway from activities to outcomes
- **Process Evaluation** - How program is implemented
- **Impact Evaluation** - Whether program creates change
- **Cost-Effectiveness Analysis** - Economic evaluation of interventions